

Need a laugh?

Follow this link to get a random funny video of men being bungling idiots:
<http://dgit.in/heroindr>

Heroin addiction caused by what?

An article on New Republic says heroin epidemics don't come and go randomly. The largest cause, they say, is doctor-prescribed pills. Find out more: <http://dgit.in/heroindr>

Your online privacy may be at risk

We take a look at the important developments over the last month that could have a major impact on your online security

Kul Bhushan

readersletters@thinkdigit.com

WhatsApp CEO reassures users about privacy issues

Facebook's \$19 billion acquisition of WhatsApp last month was followed by concerns over privacy of the app's 450 million plus users. Privacy advocates even sought to block the deal, stating that the sale would hurt WhatsApp users by allowing their data to be merged into Facebook's advertising business. WhatsApp's co-founder and CEO Jan Koum took to his company's blog to assure users that the company won't be gathering additional user data for Facebook's massive advertising business.

"You don't have to give us your name and we don't ask for your email address," Jan said. "We don't know your likes, what you search for on the internet or collect your GPS location. None of that data has ever been collected and stored by WhatsApp, and we really have no plans to change that."

He also emphasised that the deal with Facebook is a partnership and none of WhatsApp's principles would change. "If partnering with Facebook meant that we had to change our values, we wouldn't have done it. Our future partnership with Facebook will not compromise the vision that



WhatsApp Co-Founder and CEO Jan Koum

brought us to this point," he added. Mark Zuckerberg also stated in a recent interview that Facebook had no plan to put ads in WhatsApp. His primary goal is to reach 1 billion monthly active users by year-end with a host of new services such as free voice calling.

NSA capable of recording all calls of a nation!

The National Security Agency (NSA) of USA has reportedly developed a surveillance system, which is capable of recording "100 percent" telephone calls of a foreign country. According to *The Washington Post*, the new system enables the agency to rewind and review conversations as long as a month after they take place. People with direct knowledge of the effort and documents supplied by former NSA contractor Edward Snowden have revealed

these latest activities of the intelligence agency.

The program which began way back in 2009 is a voice-interception program called MYSTIC. The system is said to have reached full capacity against the first target nation in 2011.

According to classified summary from one of the documents, the collection systems are recording "every single" conversation nationwide and storing billions of them in a 30-day rolling buffer that clears the oldest calls as new ones arrive. The summary also says that the call buffer opens a door "into the past," enabling users to "retrieve audio of interest that was not tasked at the time of the original call."

The documents further say that the analysts listen to only a fraction of 1 percent of the calls, but the absolute number is said to be higher. Each month, these analysts send millions of voice clippings, or "cuts," for processing and long-term storage.

The MYSTIC program is special for NSA in a sense that all of the agency's programs that have been unveiled till now have involved bulk collection of metadata and not call content.

The principal technologist for the American Civil Liberties Union, Christopher Soghoian said that history suggests "over

the next couple of years they will expand to more countries, retain data longer and expand the secondary uses."

Mark Zuckerberg expresses frustration over NSA, calls President Obama

Facebook CEO Mark Zuckerberg called on U.S. President Barack Obama to express his frustration regarding the



The emblem of the program depicts a cartoon wizard with a telephone-headed staff

National Security Agency's (NSA) surveillance practices.

Zuckerberg put up a status update on Facebook saying, "I've called President Obama to express my frustration over the damage the government is creating for all of our future. Unfortunately, it seems like it will take a very long time for true full reform."

The update came a day after new documents were leaked by whistle-blower Edward Snowden which revealed that NSA was using an automated